

3.6 Serializing arrays

The `serialize()` function is used to generate a representation of values that the array holds. This means that it is used to serialise some PHP values. It stores the PHP values without losing its type and structure. These serialised values can be un-serialised by using the `unserialize()` function. The `serialize()` function can not serialise the variables of type 'Resource'.

Example 1:

```
<?php
// $session_data contains a multi-dimensional
array with session
// information for the current user. We use seri-
alize() to store
// it in a database at the end of the request.

$con = odbc_connect("webdb", "php", "bird");
$a = odbc_prepare($con,
    "UPDATE sessions SET data = ? WHERE id =
?");
$sqldata = array (serialize($session_data),
$_SERVER['PHP_AUTH_USER']);
if (!odbc_execute($a, &$sqldata)) {
    $a = odbc_prepare($con,
        "INSERT INTO sessions (id, data) VALUES(?,
?)" );
    if (!odbc_execute($a, &$sqldata)) {
        /* Something went wrong.. */
    }
}
?>
```

Example:

```
<?php
if($_POST[submit]) {
    $ourarray = array(); // New, blank array.
    foreach($_POST as $key => $a) {
        if($key!="submit") { // We want to exclude the
submit button
            $ourarray[$key] = $a;
        }
    }
}
```